

An Adulting Checklist for College-Bound Students

Published: JULY 29, 2026

Source: <https://www.franklintempleton.com/articles/en/2026/07/an-adulting-checklist-for-college-bound-students>

Extraction method: selenium

As families prepare for college move-in season, the packing list usually starts with the obvious essentials: bedding, a laptop, chargers, school supplies and plenty of snacks.

But once a student turns 18, families may discover that some familiar support systems work differently. Access to medical, financial and educational information may require the student's permission, even in situations where parents are simply trying to help.

Many families focus on tuition bills, meal plans and dorm supplies, but turning 18 also changes who can access important information.

That is why a few documents are worth discussing before move-in day: a health care proxy, a Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA) authorization, a durable power of attorney and any school-specific releases related to the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA).

Health Care Proxy: Choosing Someone to Help Make Medical Decisions

A health care proxy allows a student to name someone, often a parent or guardian, to make medical decisions on their behalf if they become unable to do so.

A health care proxy generally addresses who can make medical decisions if the student cannot, while a HIPAA authorization addresses who may receive certain medical information. Some students may also choose to complete a living will or advance directive to document health care preferences.

HIPAA Authorization: Access to Medical Information

HIPAA generally restricts health care providers from sharing an adult patient's medical information without permission.

That can surprise parents who assume they can obtain information because their child remains on the family's health insurance plan.

A HIPAA authorization may allow a student to identify who can receive information about their medical condition, treatment or records when appropriate.

Medical information is only one piece of the picture. Families may also want to think about how financial or legal matters would be handled if help were needed.

Durable Power of Attorney: Managing Financial Matters

A durable power of attorney may authorize a trusted person to assist with certain financial or legal matters on behalf of the student, depending on state law and the terms of the document.

For example, it may help a parent or other representative access certain financial accounts, sign specified documents, assist with transactions or handle administrative matters if the student becomes unable to do so.

Access questions can also arise in the academic setting.

FERPA and Student Records

FERPA generally limits a college's ability to share a student's educational records without the student's consent.

Many schools offer parent portals or FERPA authorization forms that allow students to grant access to certain academic or financial information.

Families may wish to review these options before classes begin rather than waiting until information is needed.

A Conversation Worth Having

College is more than a move into a dorm room; it is often one of a young adult's first chances to make important

decisions independently.

Discussing health care wishes, financial responsibilities and privacy preferences may not be as exciting as shopping for a new laptop, but it can be an important part of preparing for life away from home.

Before move-in day, families may want to identify emergency contacts, review school-specific access forms, choose where signed documents will be stored and consider whether professional guidance is needed.

As students finalize their back-to-school checklists, these planning documents may deserve a place alongside the other essentials for a life away from home.

Because laws governing health care proxies, powers of attorney and educational records vary by state, families should consult qualified legal, tax and financial professionals about their specific circumstances before executing any legal documents.

Follow Bill Cass, CFP, CPWA

WHAT ARE THE RISKS?

All investments involve risks, including possible loss of principal.

Any information, statement or opinion set forth herein is general in nature, is not directed to or based on the financial situation or needs of any particular investor, and does not constitute, and should not be construed as, investment advice, forecast of future events, a guarantee of future results, or a recommendation with respect to any particular security or investment strategy or type of retirement account. Investors seeking financial advice regarding the appropriateness of investing in any securities or investment strategies should consult their financial professional.

Franklin Templeton, its affiliated companies and its employees are not in the business of providing tax or legal advice to taxpayers. These materials and any tax-related statements are not intended or written to be used, and cannot be used or relied upon, by any such taxpayer for the purpose of avoiding tax penalties or complying with any applicable tax laws or regulations. Tax-related statements, if any, may have been written in connection with the "promotion or marketing" of the transaction(s) or matter(s) addressed by these materials, to the extent allowed by applicable law. Any such taxpayer should seek advice based on the taxpayer's particular circumstances from an independent tax advisor.

WF: 11653159